

Bluefish-The Feature Rich Editor

This light and fast open source editor, best suited for Web development, is available across multiple platforms and supports many programming languages. The editor has also been translated to Tamil.



Bluefish is an open source editor that is highly customisable. It supports many programming, scripting and mark-up languages. The editor can be extended by adding external programs such as filters and by also adding snippets of code. As it is an open source project, new features and language support, too, can be added. This article is based on the latest version of Bluefish 2.2.4 on Windows.

Cross-platform support

The cross-platform support is very useful if you choose to master just one editor for all your programming or mark-up needs. If your work environment is Microsoft Windows and the home PC has a Mac or Linux OS (or vice versa), then a cross-platform editor is extremely useful.

Light and fast

The binary size of the latest version of Bluefish (2.2.4) on Windows is around 4.2 MB. Over the years, it has improved both on features and performance. From version 1.0 to the latest, the editor has improved on the maximum file size it can handle and also the number of files that can be opened simultaneously.

Multiple language support for the Web programming languages, in particular

The list of programming languages that Bluefish supports is

large, the most popular ones being C, C++ and Java. In mark-up languages, it supports HTML5 and ColdFusion Markup language. The scripting languages it supports are Perl, Python, Ruby, PHP, JavaScript and VBScript.

The editor is translated into 17 languages such as Russian, Japanese, Chinese and Tamil. It is best suited for Web development and deployment on Web servers.

Basic editing with Bluefish

Screen layout and panels

The editor has a menu bar, toolbar, tabs for quick access HTML mark-up, a file browser and editing area. At the bottom of the screen is the command output and status bar. The complete UI layout is customisable, with an option to hide/show panels. The menus are tearable, for accessing the most frequently-used menu items quickly. The side panel on the left gives views of the file browser, bookmarks, character maps and code snippets. Bookmarks and snippets are special features in Bluefish, which we will cover in upcoming articles.

In the side panel with the file browser view, one can perform operations on files like *rename*, *delete*, *create new file*, etc.

Standard project support

When working on Web projects or Java, one works with a set of files, which can be grouped as one project. You can create